2. **Determinate:** The terminal bud caese to grow after a period of growth and the further growth is taken care by successive or several lateral meristem or buds. This type of growth is also known as **sympodial branching.** Example: *Cycas*.

3.7 Leaf

Leaves are green, thin flattened lateral outgrowths of the stem. Leaves are the primary photosynthetic organs and the main site of transpiration. All the leaves of a plant together are referred to as **phyllome**.

I. Characteristics of leaf

1. Leaf is a lateral appendage of the stem.
2. It is borne at the node of the stem.
3. It is exogenous in origin.
4. It has limited growth.
5. It does not posses apical bud.
6. It has three main parts namely, leaf base, petiole and lamina.
7. Lamina of the leaf is traversed by vascular strands, called **veins.**

II. Functions of the leaf

Primary functions

1. Photosynthesis
2. Transpiration
3. Gaseous exchange
4. Protection of buds
5. Conduction of water and dissolved solutes.

Secondary functions

1. Storage – Example: *Aloe, Agave*.
2. Protection – Example: *Opuntia, Argemone mexicana*.
3. Support – Example: *Gloriosa, Nepenthes*.
4. Reproduction - Example: *Bryophyllum, Begonia, Zamia*.

3.7.1 Parts of the leaf

Three main parts of a typical leaf are:

i. Leaf base (Hypopodium)
ii. Petiole (Mesopodium)
iii. Lamina (Epipodium)

I. Leaf base (hypopodium)

The part of the leaf attached to the node of the stem is called **leaf base.** Usually it protects the growing buds at its axil.

Pulvinus: In legumes leaf base become broad and swollen which is known as **pulvinus.** Example: *Clitoria, Lablab, Cassia, Butea*.

Sheathing leafbase: In many monocot families such as Arecaceae, Musaceae, Zingiberaceae and Poaceae the leafbase extends into a sheath and clasps part or whole of the internode. Such leafbase also leave permanent scars on the stem when they fall.

II. Petiole (stipe or mesopodium)

It is the bridge between lamina and stem. Petiole or leaf stalk is a cylindrical or sub cylindrical or flattened structure of a leaf which joins the lamina with the stem. A leaf with petiole are said to be **petiolate.** Example: *Ficus, Hibiscus.* Leaves that do not possess petiole is said to be **sessile**. Example*: Calotropis.*

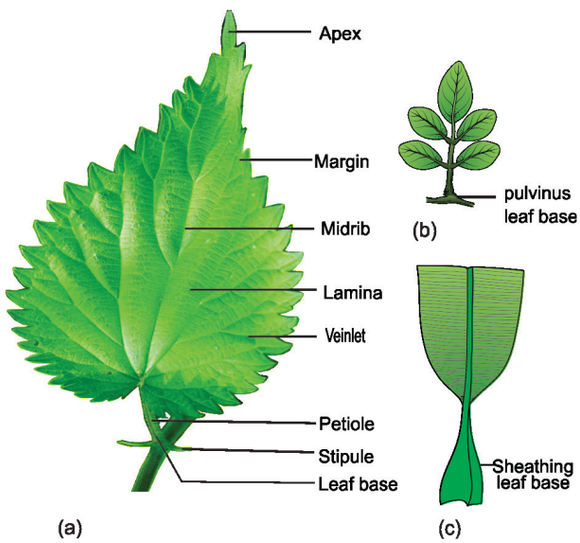


Figure 3.11: (a) Parts of the leaf **(b)** Pulvinus leaf base **(c)** Sheathing leaf base

III. Lamina (Leaf blade)

The expanded flat green portion of the leaf is the blade or lamina. It is the seat of photosynthesis,

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